



THE INSTITUTE OF
MASTERS
of WINE

Practical Report

2023 Stage 2 MW Exam

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Practical Exam Chair Report, Peter Marks MW

This year's overall pass rate is similar to last year's (13.5% in 2023 vs. 13.3% in 2022) with 18 out of 133 candidates having achieved an overall pass. Congratulations to those who have done so well this year! For those who did not pass, there are encouraging signs. For 2023 practical candidates, the average score across three papers was 56.3%, which represents a C grade. This is the highest overall score in recent years: 54.6% (D) in 2022, 52.4% (D) in 2021, 55.0% (C) in 2019, 52.2% (D) in 2018, and 52.7% (D) in 2017.

Prior to moderation, there were 9 candidates who achieved a passing score of 65% or more. I closely review those candidates' papers who are close to passing (generally between 60.0% to 64.9%) but have not achieved an overall pass due to one or two papers that fall below the 65% threshold. After moderating 28 'borderline' candidates, an additional 9 individuals achieved a pass. Reviewing all three papers allows one to clearly see strengths and weaknesses, whether the candidate shows convincing logic even if wrong, whether they recognize and clearly depict quality, style, and commercial aspects, and whether they can relate evidence from the glass to correctly distinguish winemaking techniques. Going into the practical exam you know what types of questions will appear, but on certain days there might be more emphasis on quality and maturity, whereas on another day the focus may be on winemaking. You need to be able to tackle these questions from the lens of all types of wines – white, rose, orange, red, sparkling, and fortified. In other words, you must demonstrate consistency over three days of tasting and justify your answers convincingly and with confidence to demonstrate you are a Master of Wine.

Those borderline candidates who earned a pass after moderation tended to do well with identification of origin and grape variety, yet this alone is not sufficient. When they recognize a wine, they demonstrate confidence by efficiently using relevant and correct evidence to prove their point. When unsure, these candidates offered reasonable alternatives based on evidence from the glass and then argued logically even if their conclusion was wrong instead of trying to shoehorn their answer. In addition, they offer original responses to commercial potential questions by using their theory knowledge instead of offering rote responses.

This year's practical exam was different in that even less emphasis was placed on identification of origin and grape varieties. Only 39% of all marks were devoted to identification questions (compared to 46% last year) whereas 37% of the marks related to quality, maturity, and aging potential (compared to 24% last year). While you know what types of questions will be asked on the practical exam, you never know where the weighting will be, and it's important to study and practice all aspects, not just identification.

The weakest marks on this year's exam came from Paper 2 with a 14.3% pass rate compared to 21.1% for Paper 1 and 23.3% for Paper 3. There doesn't appear to be anything unusual about Paper 2. In fact, this paper included a good number of so-called classic wines (Barolo, Rioja, Bordeaux, Mendoza Malbec) and very few outliers. However, this paper comprehensively tested a wide range of tasting skills which were not satisfactorily addressed, especially quality and maturity, production methods (and use of oak), as well as commercial position. Once again, this shows that being able to identify wines is only part of the equation.

The following reports by the Paper Chairs offer great insight and advice. I encourage candidates to study them carefully. If there are further questions or if anything is unclear, please contact Sarah Harrison and she will forward your inquiry to the Practical Exam Team. Please know that the practical examiners put in an enormous amount of time to create, source, and mark the tasting exam, and I can't thank them enough for all their efforts. Believe it or not, we want candidates to pass, but you must put in the work and believe in yourself.

Lastly, this report comes on the heels of the sudden and tragic loss this summer of Phil Tuck MW, an amazing person, dear friend, and former Practical Chair. One of Phil's greatest pieces of advice, which is more true today than it ever was, is to be honest with yourself. Put your ego aside when attending course days and seminars and heed the advice of MWs; don't make excuses and don't be afraid to ask questions; admit to your weaknesses and work on them. If you do that, you will learn to have that calm, knowing confidence that will allow you to become a Master of Wine.

Paper one report 2023: Paper chair, Lisa Perrotti-Brown MW

Apart from one unorthodox question, 2, this year's Practical Paper 1 should have been straightforward. There were no esoteric grapes or regions here —nothing to favor those with specialist knowledge of quirky wines. Candidates with considerable tasting experience, communication skills, broad technical knowledge, and sound logic expected of an MW did very well. Those who did not do well should consider gaining more experience before reattempting.

Question 1

Question 1 was designed, on the one hand, to test students' identification and deductive reasoning skills with a pair of two well-known grapes that are often blended. The identification (part a) should have been straightforward, although a few students stumbled at this first hurdle and never quite recovered. This was generally an indicator of a candidate not being ready to take the exam or having bad first-day jitters. On the other hand, the major points for this question were given to winemaking, quality, and aging potential. Therefore, students could have misidentified the varieties and still passed this question based on tasting experience and sound logic. Overall, this question was well answered.

Question 2

Question 2 was more challenging. Once again, the grape varieties should have been fairly easy to identify: German Riesling, Rhône Viognier, Sonoma Chardonnay, and Alsace Muscat. But the big points went towards the unconventional part of the question, asking students to describe the acidity and texture of the wines, commenting on the contribution of these attributes to quality. Predictably, this is where several candidates became unstuck. We were looking for accurate descriptions of the acidity and texture of each wine, followed by a conclusion of how these contributed to quality elements such as balance and complexity. Part "c" of the question about aging potential was well-answered, but many ignored the other half of this question, which asked about how the wine might evolve. The best answers described both positive and negative evolution trajectories.

Question 3

Regarding identification, question 3 appeared to be the most difficult. South Africa being represented as a full flight in the practical exam is rare. Few nailed the country, but much leeway was given to well-argued wrong answers, such as France and Chile. Many correctly identified the grape varieties and relative quality levels. Answers for part "c"—the final part about quality and market potential—were mostly lackluster or incomplete. Students must remember to save energy resources for the last part of the exam, which is often the easiest to answer well and gain full marks!

Paper two report 2023: Paper chair, Ulf Sjödin MW

The paper was mostly very straightforward, although Q3 seems to have raised some questions for a few students. The great majority seems to have understood the question without problems though.

The examiners were happy to see that most students managed to finish the paper, and that the quality of answers were generally better this year. The key is to try to communicate from an MW to an MW where on a quality scale this wine would be placed. There are many ways to do that, and many students showed that they knew how to communicate quality, which is a key competence for an MW.

There is, however, room for improvement. Some students still failed to talk about quality in the context of the region, and for W7 many students stopped at "Grand Cru Classé quality" although there is a rather large span between the top and bottom performers within that group.

Commercial position was also better expressed although many answers were rather incomplete. When monopolies in Scandinavia and Canada were mentioned, it was generally in connection with basic quality wines. Students should be careful to associate high volume wines with certain markets, since these qualities are at least as common in Germany, UK or USA or other places all over the world where wine is consumed by people with no ambition to become MWs.

Steakhouses are often mentioned. Seems to be a trend this year. In general, many students stayed with the On-Trade on Commercial Position, thus losing a mark or two. The examiners were happy to see that food recommendations were much less common this year.

Q1: This was the best answered question in the paper, and a great majority of students went to Italy on Q1. Those who didn't had small chances of passing the paper although a lot of marks could be gained from quality/maturity and winemaking questions. Many students got wines 1 and 4 correct, which probably reflects the popularity of Barolo and Etna Rosso. W2 was surprisingly often identified as Dolcetto, and W3 was only identified by a small number of students. Those who were familiar with the combination of moderate acidity and very high, dry tannins could take the opportunity to shine.

Q2: Many students managed to identify the residual sugar and basic quality level of wine 5. Those who didn't should take some time to taste supermarket wines more often. Rioja Reserva, Coonawarra Cabernet or Napa Valley Merlot are not reasonable suggestions for this wine. Any New World generic origin generated good marks if quality was used as an argument.

The Rioja and the Bordeaux were correctly identified by many students. The brett in W7 didn't seem to cause too much problem for most students, as this was the most well answered wine in Q2.

Many students went for Grenache on W8, and any plausible origin could get good marks if well argued.

Q3: Those students who managed to identify the Burgundy, and the Argentinian Malbec, had an easy task in filling out the two blanks. Sadly, the Malbec turned out to be more difficult than expected. Decent marks could be earned for Syrah, if the choice of origin made sense.

Many students should have used funnelling techniques more or referred to the other wine in the pair for support of their choice of origin. If you, as an example, go straight to Napa Valley for W10 (which is from Cahors), without any arguments for why that is such a natural choice, you will gain very few marks, if any.

Paper three report 2023: Paper chair, Peter Mitchell MW

Paper 3 contained many pointers in the questions and looked to test candidates' theory knowledge, as well as their ability to recognise winemaking techniques and quality from the glass.

It was generally well answered with a few outstanding papers that shone, and this is reflected by a 23% pass rate, although in a paper that did not require copious amounts of writing, it was a little disappointing there were some potentially good candidates who struggled for time and so lost valuable marks.

I would once again urge all those sitting the exam to read the question carefully. Having been told all the first 4 wines were traditional method, a surprising number went on to unnecessarily describe how they deduced it was traditional method in their answers on origin. Similarly, when asked to assess the quality in the context of the origin, many made no reference to the origin and later in the paper when asked to compare production methods, no comparison was forthcoming.

Winemaking was generally well tackled, although it was noticeable how many candidates missed the obvious new oak use on wines 6, 8 and 11.

Maturity assessments also still seem to cause some problems, with a number of candidates not fully answering them. For maturity there needs to be an assessment of the current age of the wine, whether it is ready to drink now or would benefit from further ageing and, if so, how long it might improve for, and finally how long it is likely to hold before it declines. Examiners are aware this is not a precise science and personal tastes also come into the equation, but these questions provide a real opportunity for candidates to shine with their assessments.

Quality, which was addressed in all four flights, saw many good answers with wines placed on the quality ladder with context and the majority of papers scored very good marks in these questions.

Finally, an increasing number of answers appear repetitive and are clearly using cut and paste. It is unlikely examiners have chosen two wines with the same attributes, so whilst this method might save time, it is unlikely to impress the markers of your abilities.

Question 1

With the help given in the question, this was a relatively straightforward flight with 3 classic styles and one wine that was more challenging. The majority spotted the Cava, although a surprising number missed its obvious brut nature style and the English sparkling was also well identified, with the best candidates also identifying it as a Blanc de Blancs with extensive lees ageing. The Riesling had a strong varietal character and saw some excellent answers, but it clearly was a style that not all candidates were aware of resulting in some poor identification. The Crémant was the most challenging wine to identify but marks could be earned for well-reasoned answers. Quality assessments were broadly well answered, although too few candidates referred to the length of time on the lees in their answers.

Question 2

Three classic and different styles of rosés with some very good answers. The Champagne was identified by the majority, although quality assessments varied wildly and surprisingly few commented on the relatively deep colour. In the winemaking, too few considered the use of reserve wines or gave an accurate assessment of the time spent on lees. For wine 6, the best candidates discussed alternatives to Provence whilst correctly identifying it. Winemaking needed to address the very pale colour and extensive use of oak and identifying the ambitious nature and very high quality was essential. This was a wine that gave candidates a chance to show theory knowledge and the best excelled. Wine 7 was identified by name by a handful of candidates and in general elicited some good answers. The small amount of residual sugar took some erroneously to California, but marks could still be earned for quality and winemaking.

Question 3

Some good answers but also some of the most lacking were on this question. Identification was generally well tackled and most that had the identification wrong generally misidentified alcohol or acidity and were in Sauternes or the Loire, however with good answers to parts b) and c), could still achieve strong marks. Those who missed the botrytis on wine 9 ended up going badly wrong.

The question asked for a comparison of the production methods yet few managed to do this, with many just listing how botrytised wine is made with little or no reference to the glass and covering the dry wine in very little detail, with many missing the obvious new oak. A question like this requires a logical progression comparing the two wines. Quality answers were much better, but maturity was seldom completely answered (see the general comments above).

Question 4

On the face of it a straightforward question but as the wording of the question and style of the wines made identifying the variety fairly straightforward, to get maximum marks here candidates needed to show how they had reached the conclusion and why they had discarded any other options, going into some detail about the structural elements of the wines. The best answers wove a beautiful argument, far too many were lacking any justification beyond 'it can only be Grenache'.

Wine 10 was well identified and both quality and winemaking were well answered, although it is worth noting that examiners expect some reasonable time frame for the long maturation, not just 'matured for many years' as cropped up a few times. Wines 11 and 12 seemed more of a challenge with the majority of candidates plumping for Sierra de Gredos for one or other of the wines with McLaren Vale as their other choice. In many cases there was a feeling of trying to second guess the examiners choices and little demonstration of knowledge of where Grenache wine is made. Although there were some near perfect answers, too few seemed to assess the structural components and fruit profiles of the two wines and thus make well-reasoned arguments for the origin. The two wines also had contrasting production methods and maturity which gave an opportunity to shine, but again too few gained really high marks here.